

journey, Prof. Sadagopan's people-centric approach radiates. He says, "When people ask me what is the one thing about which I am proud, I mention my contribution to an unusual employability enhancement project. It was initiated in IIIT Bangalore by Smt Meira Kumar, the former Speaker of the Lok Sabha. We took some 100 students who happened to be unemployed engineers belonging to SC/ST communities. They were facing difficulties in getting jobs, even though some reservations were available to them. We felt that if we give them world-class courses, curriculum, and facilities, they would be able to get jobs in world-class companies. We ran a competition to select students for special training. We designed and conducted a one-year training program for them. I used to be involved with each of them intensely. We also got funding from Infosys for providing laptops to each trainee. At the end of the training, all of them got jobs in big companies, including IBM, HP, etc." Later, the same model was replicated more than once and Prof. Sadagopan's closeness with his students continues to grow as he narrates, "I get very close to my students. I have known them and their families for the last 30 to 40 years."

Prof. Sadgopan was also involved with an e-governance project fundamentally. He mentions, "I interacted with senior level bureaucrats, political leaders including chief ministers, ministers, prime ministers, etc. As a teacher, I always feel touched to see the respect given to the teachers in our country. I keep telling my American friends that a professor at Harvard University is respected firstly because of his association with Harvard, and secondly because he is also a reasonably rich guy. However, in our country, teachers are respected irrespective of their economic condition."

Few of Prof. Sadagopan's favourite things

- **Music:** Devotional Carnatic music
- **Books:** Reads lots of books but not novels. The 'Autobiography of A Yogi' by Paramahansa Yogananda is one of his favourite books. He is also quite influenced by the collected works of Swami Vivekananda and Sri Aurobindo.
- **Food:** Traditional vegetarian food

Prof. Sadagopan follows an interesting mentoring style which he partly learned from his professor. He remembers, "My professor told me that there are two ways in which he can guide me. In the first option, he had multiple projects with predefined scopes. Therefore, I could join any one of those and complete my PhD in a reasonably fast time. But in this method, I would miss the fun of defining my problem. In the second option, I would be allowed to define my problem and solve the same under the guidance of my PhD supervisor. The second option required more time, but it was more interesting. Therefore, I opted for the second option." Prof. Sadagopan also follows the same style while mentoring his students. Rather than defining their problems, he encourages them to identify some interesting problems and solve them.

"The mentor should be like a life coach. The life coach should always be around. He should allow you to jump into the water and play as long as you can. Only when you are likely to be risking your life, the life coach should come into play; otherwise he should just be observing. That is my mentorship model."

His wife is a constant support and a part of his extended academic life. Prof. Sadagopan says, "My wife is a simple person. She has been a great support for me in lots of things that I would not have been able to do. Just like me, her life centres around our students. She also travels with me to most places and

most of the students know her. Lots of times they come to visit her at home even if I am not there and love to taste South Indian coffee and food made by her." She is also a good typist and used to help his students in typing their projects, especially those who were not able to arrange a laptop or personal computer for typing. Due to her support, many students mention her name in the acknowledgment section of their MTech and PhD theses. These students include many celebrity technocrats, for example, the current CEO of TCS K Krithivasan, and the current IT Minister Ashwini Kumar Vaishnav.

Prof. Sadagopan is closely associated with IIIT Bangalore (IIITB) even after his formal retirement. Recently, he and his wife attended the Convocation 2023, where Integrated MTech students of the year 2018 graduated. "Many parents remembered his request way back in 2018 at the time of admissions, to visit IIITB only after 5 years to see their wards graduate, with the assurance that the wards will be safe in IIITB! I forgot the same, but my students and their parents remembered and asked me if I would keep my pledge. I had no option but to be there!"

Prof. Sadagopan would like to remain active with his work and students until the last moment of his life. "I would like to keep working until the last minute and disappear just like that. That's what I want. Whether it is one year from now or 10 years from now or 30 years from now." **END** 🐧

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